



IRAQI security forces join a Baghdad parade marking the U.S. troop withdrawal from the nation Wednesday.

AHMAD AL-RUBAYE AFP/Getty Images

VIOLENT ATTACK THWARTED ON FLIGHT TO ISRAEL

Passengers intervene after one pilot stabs another. The plane drops but lands safely.

By SAMY MAGDY, MELANIE LIDMAN, ISAAC SCHARF AND JOSH FUNK

TEL AVIV — A pilot stabbed a fellow pilot Wednesday on a flight to Israel before passengers burst into the cockpit and wrestled with the attacker as the plane descended sharply and passengers screamed, witnesses said. The jetliner was stabilized and made an emergency landing in Saudi Arabia.

It was unclear what motivated the attack, which led Israel to scramble warplanes amid concerns about a possible hijacking. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Saudi Arabia arrested the pilot, who was not identified.

The shaken passengers from the FlyDubai flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv landed Wednesday evening in Israel on another flight, as onlookers cheered.

“We’re going to die,” passenger Naama Bershadski recalled thinking as she closed her eyes and prayed.

Aviation experts were surprised that the plane did not crash after a descent so extreme that most of the rudder was ripped off the tail.

A video shared by Netanyahu’s office showed passenger Yaniv Hayoun, who grappled with the attacker, wearing a bloodied shirt and hugging the prime minister, who told him: “I look at you and I see a lion. I see a great hero.”

After a passenger saw one pilot stab the other and called out for help, Hayoun said, he and others pushed into the cockpit, where he saw the unharmed pilot apparently trying to destroy

[See **Israel**, A3]

Bass and Raman split on Gaza and ‘genocide’

By DAVID ZAHNISER AND NOAH GOLDBERG

The candidates for Los Angeles mayor gave opposing takes on the war in Gaza on Tuesday night, with Councilmember Nithya Raman saying Israel has committed genocide and Mayor Karen Bass asserting the term is inappropriate.

Appearing back to back at the Skirball Cultural Center, Bass and Raman both said they would fight to keep L.A.’s Jewish residents safe.

But Raman faced a spate of questions about her sit-down interview with leftist Twitch streamer Hasan Piker, a vehement critic of Israel, and her support from Democratic Socialists of America,

which has called for the boycott of and divestment from Israel over its treatment of Palestinians.

Moderator Alex Cohen, seated next to Raman onstage, asked the council member to explain her decision to portray Israel’s actions as genocide, calling it a “highly inflammatory term.”

Raman said she turned to international experts — including some Israeli experts — to make her decision.

“That is what guided me to using that term in describing what’s happening in Gaza,” she said. “I used it because I felt compelled to

[See **Forum**, A6]



MODERATOR Alex Cohen listens as Mayor Karen Bass speaks at a forum.

ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

Land conservation on track

California nears its goal of preserving 30% by 2030

By NOAH HAGGERTY

After adding more than a million acres in the last year, California is on track to meet its goal of conserving 30% of its land by 2030, officials announced Tuesday.

However, the state lags in its efforts to conserve 30% of its coastal waters in the same time frame. Since Gov. Gavin Newsom established the “30x30” initiative in 2020, virtually all of the increase in protected waters came from a single marine sanctuary created by the federal gov-

ernment in 2024.

“We’ve made tremendous progress on land. It’s stubborn, but we’ve made progress as it relates to our coastal waters as well,” Newsom said at a 30x30 conference at the California Academy of Sciences in San Francisco. “We’re going to achieve and reach those goals, absolutely, by 2030.”

As of June, California had conserved 27.1% of its land and 21.9% of its coastal waters, according to the state’s latest progress report. Four years ago, when the state began tracking progress, it had

about 23.8% of its land and 16.2% of its coastal waters under conservation. Some of the recent gains came from recategorizing conservation agreements that had already existed.

“For us, it’s never been just an accounting exercise,” said California Natural Resources Secretary Wade Crowfoot. “It’s helping all Californians and nature thrive together: How do we protect this globally renowned biodiversity, and how do we protect the natural systems that sustain us.”

[See **Conserve**, A5]

U.S. departs Iraq, where militias’ future is unclear

Trump wants Baghdad to curb the influence of Iran and disarm the Tehran-backed groups.

By NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — America opened its “forever war” in Iraq more than 23 years ago with “Shock and Awe.” It ended it on Wednesday with little of either, even as the legacy of that conflict — which saw Iraq endure sectarian bloodbaths, civil war and an insurgency that made Baghdad the car bomb capital of the world — continues to cast its shadow on the country today.

President Trump, summing up the U.S. role in Iraq as “a very expensive excursion into Hell,” said, “This day is a victory for the United States, a victory for Iraq.... We’re getting the hell out of there.”

It was the second time U.S. forces have pulled out of Iraq. The first withdrawal took place in 2011, capping the occupation that began in 2003 and toppled Iraqi dictator Saddam Hussein, and which resulted in Iraqi deaths that number 110,000 to four times greater and the loss of about 4,500 U.S. serv-

ice members.

But three years later, Islamic State jihadists scythed through wide swaths of Iraq, scooping up U.S.-supplied materiel — as Iraqi troops literally ran away — and seizing control of nearly a third of the country. The U.S., this time at the Iraqi government’s request, led a coalition in a campaign — named Inherent Resolve — that by 2017 had destroyed Islamic State’s caliphate and driven most of its fighters into Syria. Since then, Iraqi forces have fought Islamic State remnants engaged in a low-level insurgency around the country’s remote areas.

Most U.S. and coalition forces, which numbered around 2,500, began leaving Iraq in October 2025, so that by Wednesday all that was left to withdraw were a few hundred service members stationed at Irbil air base in northern Iraq, once the operational hub of Inherent Resolve.

“Job well done to the tens of thousands of American service members, diplomats, and civilian personnel who answered the call in Iraq,” said Adm. Brad Cooper, the commander of U.S. Central Command, in a statement.

“Because of your grit,

[See **Iraq**, A3]

Newsom signs bill for journalism aid

AB 2222 will create refundable tax credits for local outlets tied to hires and retention.

By HANNAH FRY AND DAKOTA SMITH

SACRAMENTO — Gov. Gavin Newsom on Wednesday signed a landmark bill that would give a financial boost to California’s struggling newsrooms.

Assembly Bill 2222 will create refundable tax credits for California local news organizations based on the number of journalists they employ. It passed through both houses. It marks an innovative yet controversial attempt to slow the decline of local journalism.

The bill, called the Community Newsroom Employment and Workforce Sustainability Act, works by assigning a “job retention credit” of \$20,000 per journalist for up to five positions, and after that \$15,000 for every additional journalist. Part-time positions will be awarded half-credits. It also stacks an additional \$15,000 credit for each new hire to incentivize expanding journalist head counts.

The bill — believed to be the largest journalism relief plan in the U.S. to date — comes at a time of steep declines in local news outlets across the country. Many news consumers have turned their attention to social media for critical information, which has, at times, allowed misinformation to spread quickly.

During a news conference before signing the bill, Newsom spoke about what he called the “assault on the free press and the 1st Amendment ... coming from Washington, D.C., and Donald Trump.” Trump last week was forced by a federal judge to temporarily reinstate press badges for CNN, MS NOW and Politico after he banned them from accessing the White House.

“It’s journalists that need to report those stories and local journalists that need to uncover and sort of peel back the facade if democracy is going to survive, let alone thrive,” Newsom said.

The bill was supported by the California News Publishers Assn., of which the Los Angeles Times is a member, and a wide range of other community news boosters. Backers said it could be a lifeline to local news organizations.

[See **Journalism**, A6]

Becerra, Hilton face off

Scan this code for full coverage of Wednesday night’s governor debate at latimes.com and in our eNewspaper, where subscribers get “LATExtra.”

State restores wildlife program

Coexistence effort focuses on easing conflicts between humans and animals. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Warner merger settlement OKd

A judge’s ruling allows Paramount to finalize the \$111-billion takeover. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 87/66. **B6**

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ALLEN J. SCHABEN L.A. Times

Riley under fire in recent days

The USC football coach draws criticism for his handling of the late hit on Oregon quarterback Dante Moore last week. **SPORTS, B10**

Markets A11
Opinion Voices A12

Bitter abuse claims, then killing at park

A couple’s divorce fight raged on. Now her parents are charged with murder.

By HANNAH FRY

On a sunny Saturday afternoon, a man and woman wearing masks approached a man at a sprawling park in an East Bay Area suburb where children

gather to play baseball and soccer and frolic on the playground.

According to witnesses and police, the couple repeatedly shot the man in the parking lot of the Dublin Sports Grounds.

Police said they arrived at the scene and arrested the pair, quickly determining the alleged attackers were the victim’s in-laws.

The killing of Jonathan McKinsey, the director of engineering for the games de-

partment of the New York Times, stunned the East Bay community and made public a yearlong legal battle between him and his estranged wife and the in-laws now charged with killing him.

McKinsey, a 40-year-old transgender man, claimed in court documents he was on the receiving end of physical and emotional abuse and transphobic remarks by his wife, Candice Jang, and his in-laws. Jang claimed in

her own filings that she and the couple’s three young children had endured years of abuse at the hands of her husband.

Their divorce proceedings, which began in December, had been tied up with clashes over finances and custody of their 7- and 3-year-old sons and 5-year-old daughter. In court records filed this summer, each parent painted the other as abusive and unfit to care for the

[See **Shooting**, A5]